

Understanding Early Pregnancy Loss

Miscarriage What to expect, your options, and when to call — you are not alone

♥ WHAT IS A MISCARRIAGE?

A Common Loss — Not Your Fault

Miscarriage is the loss of a pregnancy before 20 weeks. Most are caused by random chromosome problems — not by anything you did, ate, or lifted.

Common Symptoms

Vaginal bleeding and crampy lower-belly pain, sometimes with passage of clots or tissue. Pregnancy symptoms (nausea, breast tenderness) may fade.

Sometimes No Symptoms

A loss can be found on a routine ultrasound before any bleeding starts (a "missed" miscarriage).

Important: bleeding in early pregnancy is common and does **not** always mean a miscarriage. An ultrasound confirms the diagnosis.

YOUR MANAGEMENT OPTIONS

If you are stable, there is **no emergency** — you have time to decide. All three options are safe and effective; the choice is yours.

- **1 Expectant (natural):** wait for the tissue to pass on its own. Good if you prefer no medicine or procedure and can wait.
- **2 Medication:** pills (misoprostol, often with mifepristone) help your body pass the tissue on a more predictable timeline, usually at home.
- **3 Surgical (uterine aspiration):** a short procedure that empties the uterus. Best for immediate, predictable completion or heavy bleeding.

We'll review the risks, benefits, and what to expect with each, and check your blood type — **Rh-negative** patients may need a RhoGAM injection.

WHAT TO EXPECT AT HOME

Bleeding & Cramping

Expect bleeding heavier than a period with cramping as tissue passes. This often peaks over a few hours, then eases.

Pain Relief

Ibuprofen (Advil/Motrin) works well for cramps. Use a heating pad and rest as needed.

Recovery

Light bleeding/spotting can last 1–2 weeks. We'll arrange follow-up to confirm the process is complete.

Use **pads, not tampons**, and avoid intercourse until bleeding stops and we've cleared you, to lower infection risk.

WHEN TO GET HELP NOW

Go to the ER / call us right away if:

- **911** Soaking **2+ maxi pads per hour for 2 hours** in a row
- **911** Feeling dizzy, faint, or your heart is racing
- **911** Fever over **100.4°F (38°C)** or shaking chills
- **911** Foul-smelling vaginal discharge
- **911** Severe belly pain not helped by medication

These can signal **heavy bleeding** or **infection** and need prompt treatment. When in doubt, call us or go to the ER — don't wait.

Caring for Your Heart, Too

Grief after a pregnancy loss is real, and everyone experiences it differently — there is no "right" way to feel or a set timeline. Be gentle with yourself, lean on people you trust, and know that a miscarriage does not mean you can't have a healthy pregnancy in the future. We're here to answer questions, support you, and plan next steps whenever you're ready. Call us anytime at **(281) 557-0300**.